

Spoken and written language

BOTH WRITTEN AND SPOKEN ENGLISH HAVE UNIQUE FEATURES.

It's important to understand the differences between written and spoken language—as well as the different uses within each—to improve these two types of communication.

The **earliest known written language** was **Sumerian**, which developed in **Mesopotamia** (modern-day Iraq) in about 2600 BCE.

Written language

Pieces of writing such as novels, letters, and newspaper articles are carefully constructed because writers usually have time to think about the words and sentences they use. This means that written English is organized into complete sentences and uses formal vocabulary and correct grammar.

Dear Jane,

I am having a wonderful time in Thailand. It's a beautiful country with a fascinating culture. The sun shines every day, so we spend most of our time at the stunning beaches, sunbathing and snorkeling. I would love to come back another year.

Love from Nick x



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Written English should be in complete sentences.

Spoken language

In general, spoken language is more spontaneous than written language, so it contains features such as repetition, pauses, and sounds like *er* or *um*. Words are often left out or shortened to speed up a conversation, and the vocabulary and pronunciation varies according to the background of the speaker.

The words *I had an* have been left out.

The words *yeah* and *awesome* are informal words used in speech.

**Hey, Jane! Yeah, awesome trip, thanks.
Good weather, good beaches...um...
we went snorkeling, too.
Can't wait to go back another time.**

People often repeat words when they are speaking.

It is more common to shorten or abbreviate words in spoken language. Here, *cannot* has been shortened to *can't* and *I* has been omitted.

People pause and fill silences with sounds when they speak.